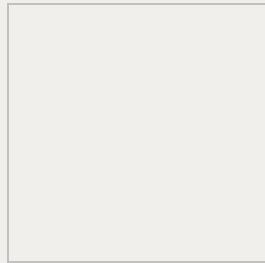


IN PROFILE

Ludwig II

Born in 1845, “Mad” King Ludwig inherited the throne of Bavaria in 1864, aged 18. From 1871, Bavaria was subsumed within the German Empire, but the king retained his title, limited powers, and a substantial revenue. Ludwig was eccentric and homosexual; his enemies claimed he was mad. He became notorious for his lavish spending on spectacular palaces such as Neuschwanstein Castle and on Wagner’s operatic projects. In 1886, his political opponents hatched a plot to replace him with a regent. Declared insane by a panel of doctors, he was deposed and drowned himself in a lake.



LUDWIG II (OR LOUIS II), KING OF BAVARIA, WILHELM TAUBNER, 1864

A total work of art

He produced a series of polemical writings—Art and Revolution, The Art of the Future, Opera and Drama—that expressed a program for a post-revolutionary culture. With capitalism overthrown, a “total work of art,” unifying music, poetry, drama, and dance, would provide the focus for the German community, the Volk (people). There was no place for “alien” Jews, whose